



1298 Dial for Ambulance

Promoters: **SWETA MANGAL** (centre), **RAVI KRISHNA**, **MANISH SACHETI** (left), **NARESH JAIN** (right), **SHAFFI MATHER**

Business: Emergency medical services

Revenue target: **Rs 5 crore by 2008**

"We wanted to start a business with a larger social purpose, not a charity."

DIALLING AN AMBULANCE in Mumbai is a nightmare. In order to bring a method to the madness, five young people with business management degrees from various American universities decided to chuck their jobs and build a high-efficiency, low-cost ambulance service for urban India. The project has been set up in association with London Ambulance Service, which has provided

processes, systems, training and project implementation assistance. The company currently operates in Kerala and Mumbai. When it receives an emergency call, it dispatches the ambulance closest to the spot and takes the patient to a hospital nearby. While all other ambulance services in the city charge Rs 3,000 and Rs 6,000 for cardiac care, 1298 charges Rs 1,500

from customers who go to private hospitals, while charging nothing from those who go to government hospitals. To augment its profits, the company sells space on the ambulance for advertising. Venture capital firm Acumen Fund has invested \$2 million (Rs 8 crore) in the company, which also runs a training division for paramedics.

through the company's information and communication technologies (ICT) network.

Drishtee, brainchild of Satyan Mishra, a Delhi School of Economics graduate, is not some philanthropic project started by a non-governmental organisation. It's a business venture that caters to the needs of the rural community. A million-dollar (Rs 4 crore) company, Drishtee is fast bridging the divide between rural and urban India through its ICT kiosks, which bring to rural areas everything

from BPO jobs to micro-finance facilities, empowering the rural folds. Companies which use the network for transactions pay a fee to Drishtee as well as the kiosk operator. Currently, the network witnesses three lakh transactions per month.

As globalisation moves across time zones, business strategists and entrepreneurs realise that sustainability requires depth and scale, neither of which is possible without moving lower down the consumption pyramid. Low-cost business models

help include all communities in the growth bandwagon. Mishra is among the many new-age entrepreneurs who are ditching high-profile corporate jobs to start businesses which serve a larger social purpose.

Call them corporate evangelists if you please. These men and women are rewriting the archaic rules of business, whereby enterprises only benefited stakeholders. These entrepreneurs are delivering innovative products and services to the economically backward classes. From affordable tractors to